

17
SKIPPER, VICTIM, SOLDIER, TERROR

THEY SAY there's a lot of politics in the Pakistan cricket team. They are probably right.

A captain is like a tower. He has to rise above the rest and provide a sense of direction. To achieve that, he has to let go of his personal issues. More than anything, he has to let go of the past, as everybody depends on him for the future.

Look at Imran Khan. We all know that he didn't personally like a lot of players who played under him. We all know he had an abrasive, confrontational, take-no-prisoners style of leadership. But he never got personal. Regardless of his own feelings about any of his players, he got the best out of them, professionally. By the way, they say that Khan, now prime minister of Pakistan, runs his cabinet the same way. More on that when I talk about his 'Naya Pakistan'.

When Shoaib Malik took charge, he couldn't replicate Imran's magnetism. He couldn't rise above the petty politics of the dressing room that had taken over during the Wasim–Waqar spat and never really stopped. His biggest problem was – and maybe it still remains to this day – that he was *kaan ka kaccha*, someone who believes everything he hears. He was prone to taking bad advice from bad people. In my opinion, he wasn't ready for the role.

I'm no diplomat, though, and I let my frustration slip out more than once about Shoaib's captaincy, and especially Butt's vice-captaincy – both bad moves from the PCB. I remember, at a preparatory camp for the 2007 World T20, there was an incident on the team bus that set the tone on where I stood on the matter.

Here's what happened: the players were in the bus, on their way to the hotel. I climbed on board and took my usual seat. Talat Ali, a very opinionated team manager at the time, told me rather rudely to get up and leave my seat for Salman Butt, the newly appointed vice-captain. I didn't budge from my seat and told Ali to take a walk. This was no way to treat the senior members of the team, I thought. In Pakistan, it's part of our culture to respect elders and seniors. Just because the team was being led by a junior, arbitrarily in charge because of an arbitrary decision by a largely arbitrary board, didn't mean that our culture of respect and achievement